

lasting impressions on everyone who chanced to see it, including the been-there-seen-that veterans. The DAH 220 is a cassette-shaped player whose semblance to the cassette tapes of yore does not end with looks. It can be inserted into a cassette player to play the stored MP3s! (There is a magnetic head that converts the digital data to analogue signals, which get processed by the music system.) While the design is intriguing, the overall build quality could have been better.

The other mobiBLU model, the DAH 1500i, is a *cube*—a perfect 24 mm cube—and claims to be the world's smallest MP3 player. With its unassuming form factor, it is easy to mistake it for a colourful die or a small paperweight, and difficult to fathom the fact that it can hold 1GB of data. Well done, mobiBLU!

Build quality is something many players in the entry segment can improve on. Barring the Megaplayer 515 and 520, the other MSI players leave a lot to be desired—surely not something you would like to gift someone. The same goes for the Genuis DJ 520, UMAX Vega 107, and the Orite Rock DJ. Sony, too, was an unpleasant surprise, with the E105 and E307 simply not feeling good enough in the hands. The saving grace for Sony here was its E503.

Of particular mention are the Samsung YP and the Creative Muvo series, which are above average when it comes to build quality and finish.

## Earphone Comfort

There is little point in having long battery life or ample storage room if your earphones cause irritation or even pain. Earphone comfort must be considered an important factor while choosing a player. In this area, the MSI Megaplayer series scored low: the earphones were actually painful when in the ears. The Megastick (256 MB) was a welcome change with its clip-on earphones—very comfortable. The XFREE, Transcend and SAFA earphones were easy on the ear, and listening to music continuously for an hour or two wasn't uncomfortable.

The earphone comfort/discomfort factor may not be the same for every person. It is therefore wise to personally check out the earphones before buying a player, or consider using earphones other than what's been supplied with the player.



mobiBLU DAH-220

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